AGENT EVALUATION
SCIENCE

Evaluating Agent Swarms: Token Budgets, Active Workers, and Baseline Choice

Maximilian Nicholson[1,2] Ayda Yazdani[1]
[1] University of Bath [2] Amazon
mn866@bath.ac.uk ay582@bath.ac.uk

Abstract

Evaluating an agent swarm requires distinguishing the effects of increasing the total token budget, dividing a fixed ceiling, and changing coordination. We examine these comparisons in 8,400 controlled trials on fresh arithmetic and graph-colouring tasks. At 4,096 completion tokens per worker, increasing independent width from one to four improves accuracy by 16.0 percentage points on both families while the total ceiling quadruples. Splitting a fixed 4,096-token completion ceiling instead lowers graph accuracy from 56.0% to 18.5%; the arithmetic change is inconclusive. The primary comparisons do not establish an accuracy advantage over a sequential control matched on scheduled calls and nominal token ceiling. Ring communication provides no consistent gain. Eleven complementary scaling studies add 20,376 held-out trials across seven task families, including a fresh-task sixteen-worker confirmation that does not establish superiority over fixed-four execution. Candidate and request audits show that finding a valid answer after an initial failure depends on the token allowance. They also reveal incomplete worker activation and 97 controlled-study attempts with unknown usage. The findings show how resource controls, output selection, and execution records qualify claims about agent scaling. They support evaluating specific allocation policies; equal realized compute advantages and general scaling laws remain unestablished from this work.

Keywords: Agent evaluation; Multi-agent systems; Test-time compute; Token budgets; Resource allocation; Coordination; Reliability; Reproducibility

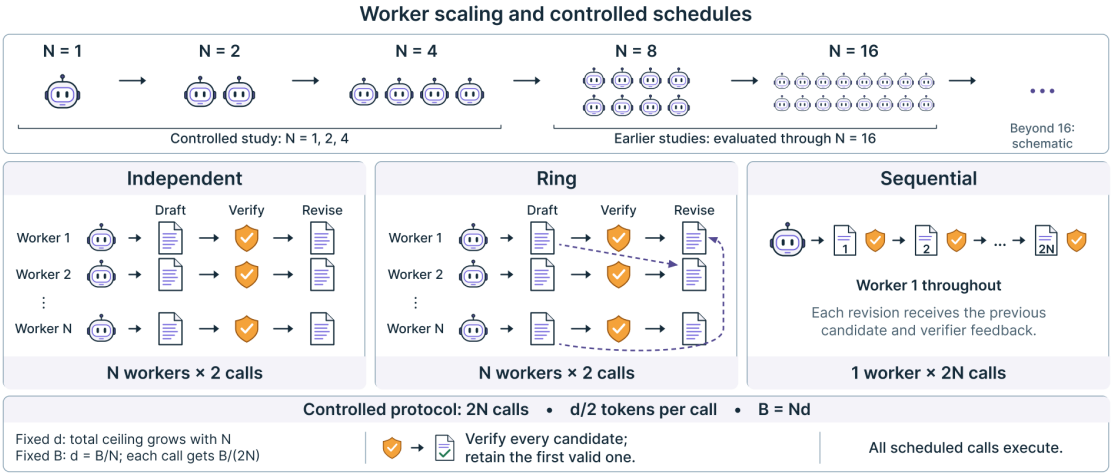


Figure 1 | Architectures and allocation: width N, per-worker completion allowance d, total ceiling $B = Nd$. All $2N$ calls execute with $d/2$ tokens per call. Controlled widths: 1, 2, 4; earlier studies: through 16. Larger widths are schematic.

> "All happy families are alike; each unhappy family is unhappy in its own way." —Leo Tolstoy, *Anna Karenina* (Tolstoy, 2014).

1 Study and Findings

This ongoing study distinguishes sampling, aggregation, and debate (Brown et al., 2024; Wang et al., 2023; Du et al., 2023), with allocation controls for task and architecture dependence (Snell et al., 2024; Kim et al., 2026). Controlled widths are $N = 1, 2, 4$ (Figure 1); programming/ZebraLogic grids use $N = 1, 2, 4, 8, 16$, diagnostics $N = 1, 4$. Task sources: BigCodeBench, MBPP/EvalPlus, ZebraLogic, BBEH, PlanBench (Zhuo et al., 2025; Austin et al., 2021; Liu et al., 2023; Lin et al., 2025; Kazemi et al., 2025; Valmeekam et al., 2023). Graph/Countdown tasks use deterministic checks; graphs adapt Reasoning Gym (Stojanovski et al., 2025). Paired bootstrap resamples task clusters, stratified where applicable (Efron, 1979; Field and Welsh, 2007).

All 148 wider cells (Figure 2) use more recorded tokens: 75 score lower, 24 equal, 49 higher. BigCodeBench Muse activation at $N = 16$ is 7.3%, 45.3%, and 93.5% at ceilings 32,768, 65,536, and 131,072. ZebraLogic $4/8/16$ minus fixed four is $+0.92$ pp (95% CI $[-0.58, 2.50]$), establishing neither superiority nor equivalence. Controlled fixed-total arithmetic: -24.0 pp, inconclusive.

At $B = 32{,}768$, independent BigCodeBench Muse passes 40/64 ($N = 1$), 36/64 ($N = 8$), and 14/64 ($N = 16$). Programming supplies 96 wider cells, 81 flat or worse; counts are not benchmark-balanced.

PlanBench's independent four-worker effect changes from -95.0 pp ($[-98.0, -91.5]$) to $+10.5$ pp ($[6.0, 15.5]$) as its ceiling doubles (higher-ceiling debit ratio: 4.06). BBEH ring effects change from -6.5 to $+4.5$ pp. Countdown's independent gains of 9.5–17.0 pp use 2.77–3.85 times the recorded tokens; its pooled ring effect is -5.0 pp ($[-8.5, -1.75]$). Our ring protocol is narrower than shared-workspace communication (Park et al., 2026).

Resource audits complement failure taxonomies (Cemri et al., 2025). Unknown usage in 97 controlled attempts limits accounting; equal ceilings do not establish equal compute. Ongoing work tests matched resources and policy transfer; general scaling laws remain unestablished. Evidence and protocols: https://github.com/PluvioXO/agent-swarms-reproducibility.

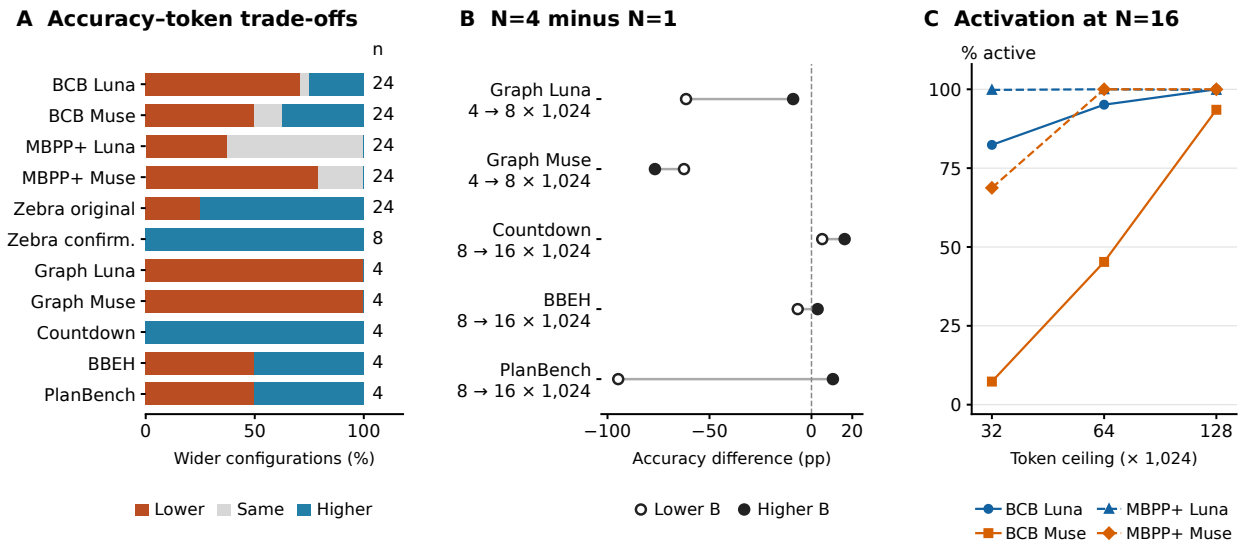


Figure 2 | (A) Wider-cell accuracy versus matched-ceiling $N = 1$ (148 configurations sharing tasks). (B) Four-worker effects at two ceilings, pooled over revision conditions. (C) Activation at sixteen requested workers.

References

Jacob Austin, Augustus Odena, Maxwell Nye, Maarten Bosma, Henryk Michalewski, David Dohan, et al. Program synthesis with large language models, 2021. https://arxiv.org/abs/2108.07732. Cited at: 1.

Bradley Brown, Jordan Juravsky, Ryan Ehrlich, Ronald Clark, Quoc V. Le, Christopher Ré, et al. Large language monkeys: Scaling inference compute with repeated sampling, 2024. https://arxiv.org/abs/2407.21787. Cited at: 1.

Mert Cemri, Melissa Z. Pan, Shuyi Yang, Lakshya A. Agrawal, Bhavya Chopra, Rishabh Tiwari, et al. Why do multi-agent llm systems fail?, 2025. https://arxiv.org/abs/2503.13657. Cited at: 1.

Yilun Du, Shuang Li, Antonio Torralba, Joshua B. Tenenbaum, and Igor Mordatch. Improving factuality and reasoning in language models through multiagent debate, 2023. https://arxiv.org/abs/2305.14325. Cited at: 1.

Bradley Efron. 1979. Bootstrap methods: Another look at the jackknife. *The Annals of Statistics*, 7(1): 1–26. https://doi.org/10.1214/aos/1176344552. Cited at: 1.

C. A. Field and A. H. Welsh. 2007. Bootstrapping clustered data. *Journal of the Royal Statistical Society: Series B (Statistical Methodology)*, 69(3):369–390. https://doi.org/10.1111/j.1467-9868.2007.00593.x. Cited at: 1.

Mehran Kazemi, Bahare Fatemi, Hritik Bansal, John Palowitch, Chrysovalantis Anastasiou, Sanket Vaibhav Mehta, et al. Big-bench extra hard, 2025. https://arxiv.org/abs/2502.19187. Cited at: 1.

Yubin Kim, Ken Gu, Chanwoo Park, Chunjong Park, Samuel Schmidgall, A. Ali Heydari, et al. Towards a science of scaling agent systems, 2026. https://arxiv.org/abs/2512.08296v3. Cited at: 1.

Bill Yuchen Lin, Ronan Le Bras, Kyle Richardson, Ashish Sabharwal, Radha Poovendran, Peter Clark, et al. Zebralogic: On the scaling limits of llms for logical reasoning, 2025. https://arxiv.org/abs/2502.01100. Cited at: 1.

Jiawei Liu, Chunqiu Steven Xia, Yuyao Wang, and Lingming Zhang. Is your code generated by chatgpt really correct? rigorous evaluation of large language models for code generation, 2023. https://arxiv.org/abs/2305.01210. Cited at: 1.

Jongho Park, Vasilis Kontonis, Shivam Garg, Akshay Krishnamurthy, and Dimitris Papailiopoulos. Scaling discovery through test-time communication, 2026. https://arxiv.org/abs/2609.21032. Cited at: 1.

Charlie Snell, Jaehoon Lee, Kelvin Xu, and Aviral Kumar. Scaling llm test-time compute optimally can be more effective than scaling model parameters, 2024. https://arxiv.org/abs/2408.03314. Cited at: 1.

Zafir Stojanovski, Oliver Stanley, Joe Sharratt, Richard Jones, Abdulhakeem Adefioye, Jean Kaddour, et al. Reasoning gym: Reasoning environments for reinforcement learning with verifiable rewards, 2025. https://arxiv.org/abs/2505.24760. Cited at: 1.

Leo Tolstoy. *Anna Karenina*. Penguin Classics, 2014. ISBN 9780141199610. https://www.penguinrandomhouse.com/books/530530/anna-karenina-by-leo-tolstoy/9780141199610/. Translated by Richard Pevear and Larissa Volokhonsky; Part One, Chapter 1. Cited at: 1.

Karthik Valmeekam, Matthew Marquez, Alberto Olmo, Sarath Sreedharan, and Subbarao Kambhampati. Planbench: An extensible benchmark for evaluating large language models on planning and reasoning about change, 2023. https://arxiv.org/abs/2206.10498. Cited at: 1.

Xuezhi Wang, Jason Wei, Dale Schuurmans, Quoc Le, Ed Chi, Sharan Narang, et al. Self-consistency improves chain of thought reasoning in language models, 2023. https://arxiv.org/abs/2203.11171. Cited at: 1.

Terry Yue Zhuo, Minh Chien Vu, Jenny Chim, Han Hu, Wenhao Yu, Ratnadira Widyasari, et al. Bigcodebench: Benchmarking code generation with diverse function calls and complex instructions, 2025. https://arxiv.org/abs/2406.15877. Cited at: 1.